

文 法 Grammar

1 ～ている (Action in Progress)

In this lesson, we will learn to use verb *te*-forms together with the helping verb いる. To understand what such a sentence means, we will need to understand the semantics of Japanese verbs. Japanese verbs can be classified into the following three types.

- (1) verbs that describe *activities* that last for some time (e.g., 食べる, 読む)
- (2) verbs that describe *changes* that are more or less instantaneous (e.g., 死ぬ, 起きる)¹
- (3) verbs that describe continuous *states* (e.g., ある, いる)

You can use verbs in the first group, such as 食べる and 読む, in their *te*-form with the helping verb いる to describe *actions in progress*.² We will discuss the verbs of the second type in the following section. The third type which describes states does not go with ている.

Activity verbs ている = action in progress

ソラさんは今勉強しています。
いまべんきょう

Sora is studying right now.

たけしさんは英語の本を読んでいます。
えいごほんよ

Takeshi is reading a book in English.

今、何をしていますか。
いま なに

What are you doing right now?

You can also use a ～ています sentence to describe what a person does by occupation or by habit. The first example below therefore has two possible interpretations: you are actually teaching English right at this moment, or you are an English-language teacher (but are not necessarily in class right now.) The second example means that Mary is in the habit of studying Japanese (but of course she does not spend 24 hours a day doing so).

¹ Among the verbs we have learned so far, verbs such as 起きる, 行く, 帰る, 来る, わかる, 出かける, 乗る, 座る, 死ぬ, 消す, 忘れる, 借りる, 降りる, 持ってくる, 連れてくる, 結婚する, 太る, やせる, 着る are change verbs. In most cases you can determine whether a verb is in the activity class or a change class by checking if the verb allows for a phrase describing duration, such as 一時間. Compare, for example,

○私はきのう一時間本を読みました。
けふ いちじかんほん

I read a book for an hour yesterday.

×私は一時間死にました。
めいし いちじかんし

(Ungrammatical, much as the English translation "I died for an hour," which is also odd.)

読む thus is an activity verb, and 死ぬ is a change verb.

² The distinction between いる and ある that we learned in Lesson 4 does not apply to this helping verb ～ている: you can use ～ている both for living things and for inanimate objects.

私は英語を教えています。
わたし えいご おし

I teach English. / I am teaching English (right now).

メアリーさんは毎日日本語を勉強しています。
まいにち に ほんご べんきょう

Mary studies Japanese every day.

The helping verb いる conjugates as a *ru*-verb. Thus we have long forms as in the following.

e.g. 食べている た	affirmative	negative
[Present]	食べています た <i>He is eating.</i>	食べていません た <i>He is not eating.</i>
[Past]	食べていました た <i>He was eating.</i>	食べていませんでした た <i>He was not eating.</i>

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2 ～ている (Result of a Change)

Verbs in the second group discussed in the previous section describe changes from one state to another. If you get married, or 結婚する, for example, your status changes from being single to being married. With these verbs, ている describes *the result of a change*.³ A change took place in the past, and its significance still remains until the present moment.

Change verbs ている = result of a change

山下先生は結婚しています。
やましたせんせい けっこん

*Professor Yamashita is married.*⁴
(= state resulting from getting married)

ゆいさんは窓の近くに座っています。
まど ちか すわ

Yui is seated near the window.
(= state resulting from seating herself there)

Here are some more examples of verbs that are commonly used in the ～ている framework.

持つ → 持っている ソラさんはお金をたくさん持っています。
も も かね
(has) *Sora has a lot of money.*

³ In Lesson 9, we will observe that this *result of a change* reading is actually not restricted to change verbs but can be associated with activity verbs in certain contexts.

⁴ Note that the sentence does *not* mean Professor Yamashita is *getting married*.

知る し	→	知っている ⁵ し (knows)	山下先生は母を知っています。 やましたせんせい はは し <i>Professor Yamashita knows my mother.</i>
太る ふと	→	太っている ふと (is overweight)	トムさんはちょっと太っています。 ふと <i>Tom is a little overweight.</i>
やせる	→	やせている (is thin)	私の弟はとてもやせています。 わたし おとうと <i>My younger brother is very thin.</i>
着る き	→	着ている き (wears)	メアリーさんはTシャツを着ています。 ティー <i>Mary is wearing/wears a T-shirt.</i>
起きる お	→	起きている お (is awake)	お父さんは起きています。 とう お <i>Dad is up and awake.</i>
住む す	→	住んでいる す (lives in)	家族は東京に住んでいます。 かぞく とうきょう す <i>My family lives in Tokyo.</i>

Note that verbs like 行く and 来る belong to the change class. Thus 行っている and 来ている indicate the result of prior movements, *not* movements that are currently in progress. You may want to be careful with what the following sentences mean.

中国に行っています。 *Somebody has gone to/is in China.* (Not: *She is going to China.*)
ちゅうごく い

うちに来ています。 *Somebody has come over to visit.* (Not: *Somebody is coming over.*)
き

You can simply use the present tense and say メアリーさんは来ます, for example, if you want to say that Mary is coming, because the present tense in Japanese refers both to the present and to the future.

3 メアリーさんは髪が長いです

To describe somebody who has long hair, one could say:

トムさんの髪は長いです。 *Tom's hair is long.*
かみ なが

But in fact it would be far more natural in Japanese to say:

トムさんは髪が長いです。 *Tom has long hair. (= As for Tom, he has long hair.)*
かみ なが

⁵ The negation of 知っています is 知りません, without the ている formation.

This applies not only to discussion of the length of one's hair, but to descriptions of a person's physical attributes in general. See the Parts of the Body section at the end of this lesson for the name of body parts.

Aさんは	$\left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{目} \\ \text{め} \\ \text{耳} \\ \text{みみ} \\ \text{手} \\ \text{て} \\ \text{足} \\ \text{あし} \\ \vdots \end{array} \right\}$	が	$\left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{大きい} \\ \text{おお} \\ \text{小さい} \\ \text{ちい} \\ \text{かわいい} \\ \vdots \end{array} \right\}$	Person A has a body part which is . . .
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In idiomatic collocations, we also have:

背が高い *is tall*
せ たか

背が低い *is short*
せ ひく

頭がいい *is bright/smart*
あたま

4 Adjective/Noun *Te*-forms for Joining Sentences

In the last lesson, we discussed the use of verbal *te*-forms to join sentences. い- and な-adjectives and です after nouns also have *te*-forms, which can be used to combine two elements to form longer sentences.

The *te*-form of an い-adjective is formed by substituting くて for the final い. The *te*-form of a な-adjective and a noun + です sequence is formed by adding で to the base or the noun.

い-adjectives:	安い	→	安くて
(irregular)	いい	→	よくて
な-adjectives:	元気(な)	→	元気で
noun + です:	日本人です	→	日本人で

あの店の食べ物は安くて、おいしいです。
みせ た もの やす

The food at that restaurant is inexpensive and delicious.

ホテルはきれいで、よかったです。

The hotel was clean, and we were happy.

山下先生は日本人で、五十歳ぐらいます。
やましたせんせい にほんじん ごじゅうさい

Professor Yamashita is a Japanese and he is about fifty years old.

As with the *te*-form conjunction of verbs in Lesson 6, you can use the *te*-form of conjunction of adjectives in sentences describing the past and the present. The last adjective determines the overall tense of each of these sentences.

5 Verb Stem + に行く

If a person moves to another place in order to do something, we can describe their movement and its purpose this way:

destination of movement	{ に へ }	the purpose of movement (verb stem)	に	{ 行く 来る 帰る }
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The purpose of movement is a phrase consisting of a verb, its object, and so forth.⁶ Verbs describing the purpose of a movement must be in their stem forms. Stems are the part you get by removing *ます* from the verbs' present tense long forms.

stems: 食べる → 食べ(ます) 読む → 読み(ます) etc.

デパートに かばんを買い に行きました。

I went to a department store to buy a bag.

メアリーさんは日本に 日本語を勉強し に来ました。

Mary has come to Japan to study Japanese.

6 Counting People

The “counter” for people is 人, but “one person” and “two people” are irregular: 一人 and 二人.

- 1 ひとり (一人)
- 2 ふたり (二人)
- 3 さんにん (三人)
- 4 よにん (四人)
- 5 ごにん (五人)
- 6 ろくにん (六人)
- 7 しちにん / ななにん (七人)
- 8 はちにん (八人)
- 9 きゅうにん (九人)
- 10 じゅうにん (十人)



何人いますか。
なんにん

To count people in a class, for example, you can add ～人 after the noun and the particle が⁶, and say:

person が X 人 います
にん

私のクラスに (は) インドネシア人の学生が一人います。
わたし じん がくせい ひとり

There is one Indonesian student in our class.

The place expressions are often followed by には instead of に in this type of sentence.

Expression Notes

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遊ぶ ▶ 遊ぶ means “to play,” “to spend time pleasantly,” or “to pay a social call.”
あそ 遊ぶ

子供の時、よく友だちと遊びました。
こども とき とも あそ

*When I was a child, I often
played with friends.*

先週の週末は東京に遊びに行きました。
せんしゅう しゅうまつ とうきょう あそ い

*I went to Tokyo to have fun
last weekend.*

私のうちに遊びに来てください。
わたし あそ き

Please come and see us.

Note that “to play” as used below requires different words.

Sports: to play tennis テニスをする

Games: to play games ゲームをする

to play cards トランプをする

Music instruments: to play the guitar ギターを弾く
ひ

知る/わかる ▶ If you don't know the answer to a question but should have thought about it, you should say わかりません instead of 知りません (see Lesson 4 Dialogue 2, for example). 知りません in such a context would sound rude, implying that your ignorance on that matter is none of the inquirer's business.

⁶ You can also use some nouns like 買い物 (shopping) for the purpose phrase, as in
デパートに買い物に行きました。 *I went to a department store for shopping.*
か もの い